

Performance

HD Tach RW

The drives performed almost on par with each other when we measured the random access times. The Seagate Pushbutton drive was one of the slower ones with 21.7 ms, while the others hovered around the 16 ms mark. However, the CPU utilisation was found to have a wide variation, with the Philips scoring 1%, and the WD My Book Pro Edition and Pro Edition II eating up 8%. The read and write speed tests did not show much variation across the segment.

SiSoft Sandra Pro Business 2007

Once again, as was the case with HD Tach, none of the drives emerged as a clear winner in SiSoft Sandra filesystem speed tests. It seemed the drives were more or less similar in terms of speed in both the assorted and sequential read as well as write tests. The Western Digital My Book Pro Edition and Pro Edition II drives were the slower performers, but we must state that we can by no measure term them as slow; the drive indices they scored were 28 and 26 respectively, while the best drive index was 30.

The access times of most of the drives were found to be somewhere in the range of 9 ms, and the slowest one in this case was the Iomega with 17 ms, which is twice as slow as that of the drives with the fastest access times.

Real-world Tests: File copy

In the 1 GB assorted data write test, the WD My Book Pro Edition II was the slowest at 58.67 seconds, while the Maxtor OneTouch III Turbo Edition exhibited, well, turbo performance, taking just 43.39 seconds. Lesser variance was seen when data was copied from the drive, that is, in the read performance. The



**Western Digital
Passport Black 80GB**
The black puma!

fastest was the Maxtor OneTouch III, and slowest was yet again the WD My Book Pro Edition II.

The Maxtor OneTouch III Turbo Edition was the fastest, while the Iomega was the slowest when 1 GB assorted files were copied from one partition to another, and there was a lot of variation this time. This test pushes the drive mechanics to the limits. The Maxtor OneTouch III Turbo Edition took just a minute and 13 seconds, while the Iomega took too long—a minute and 43 seconds.

We then transferred the assorted files simultaneously to and from the drive to push the interface to its performance limits. Once again, the Maxtor

OneTouch III Turbo Edition exhibited excellent performance, while the Iomega was the slowest. We can deduce from this that while synchronising or

backing up data, the Maxtor OneTouch III will definitely do a better job.

Portable External Hard Drives

People who need to occasionally back up their data or swap data with friends and colleagues prefer lower-capacity drives—those in this category. These are typically lighter and hence more mobile. Internally, these have laptop hard drives instead of Desktop drives.

This category consisted of just four entrants; one each from Iomega, Maxtor, Seagate, and Western Digital.

Features

Capacities And RPM

The WD Passport has the highest capacity with 160 GB, while the lowest capacity was that of the Iomega at 80 GB. The Seagate and Maxtor drives have capacities of 100 GB each. Even the lowest of these capacities is good enough for most of your backups and data transfers.

Barring the Iomega, which has a 4200 rpm hard drive, the others all sported a faster 5400. This was expected to be reflected in the tests, but as you'll see, that was not to be.

Interfaces

These drives featured only the USB 2.0 interface. The peak throughput supported by USB is 480 Mbps; you can transfer a 700 MB DivX movie in 12 seconds flat, at least theoretically, though the practical speeds are over twice as slow.

Bundled Software

We had not anticipated much with these drives (these being priced a lot lower than the Desktop External Drives) on the software front, but the Iomega Portable Hard Drive came with EMC Retrospect, a good backup software. The Maxtor OneTouch III Mini Edition came with Maxtor OneTouch Manager, which is equally good at backing up data. The WD Passport came with WD Sync. Seagate did not provide any backup software.

Real World 1 GB Copy Tests Of Top Performers

